

English Reading Practice

標準長文読解 — "Why We Love Stories" (MARCH レベル)

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高校3年

英語 (長文読解 1 題)

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Question 1 [配点 50 点]

Read the following passage and answer the questions below. Choose the best answer for each question.

Why do humans love stories? From the cave paintings of prehistoric Europe to the latest Netflix series, every human culture in history has produced narratives. We tell stories to our children before they sleep, we read novels on the train, we binge-watch dramas late into the night. (A) But why? What is it about stories that draws us in so powerfully, even when we know they are not real?

Recent research in cognitive science suggests that stories are not a luxury but a fundamental tool of human survival. The human brain, scientists argue, did not evolve to process information in lists or charts. It evolved to remember sequences of events involving people, places, and emotions — in other words, stories. When our ancestors gathered around a fire and listened to an elder describe a dangerous encounter with a predator, they were not merely being entertained. They were absorbing critical survival knowledge in the most memorable form possible.

(B) Even today, our brains respond to stories in remarkable ways. When researchers scan the brains of people listening to a vivid narrative, they find that the same regions activate as if the listener were experiencing the events directly. Read about a character running, and your motor cortex lights up. Read about a delicious meal, and your sensory regions stir. Stories, in other words, are a form of mental simulation — a way of practicing real life without taking real risks.

This explains why fiction can change us. (C) A well-told story does not just entertain; it expands the boundaries of our experience. A teenage reader who has never experienced loss can, through a novel, feel something approximating the grief of a character. A child who has never been brave can, through a fairy tale, taste the emotions of courage. By the time we close the book or leave the theater, we have lived briefly in another mind — and we return to our own lives slightly different.

There is, however, a darker side to our love of stories. The same neural machinery that makes us empathize with fictional heroes also makes us vulnerable to manipulation. (D) Politicians, advertisers, and ideologues have always known that the surest way to control human behavior is not through facts but through stories. A statistic about poverty rarely changes minds; a single vivid account of one family's struggle can move nations. This is why critical thinking matters: we must learn to ask not only "Is this true?" but also "Why is this story being told to me, and what does the teller want me to feel?"

Despite these risks, the case for stories remains strong. In an age when artificial intelligence can produce text instantly, when information swirls around us in unprecedented volumes, what makes us distinctly human may be precisely this: our ancient and unshakable need to gather around the fire, real or virtual, and listen. **(E)** Stories are not a relic of our pre-scientific past. They are the medium through which we will continue to make sense of ourselves and one another, long after the algorithms have done their work.

Perhaps, then, the question is not why we love stories, but why we would ever want to live without them.

(Original passage for Trillion School)

Notes:

cognitive science — 認知科学

motor cortex — 運動野 (脳の運動を司る領域)

mental simulation — 心的シミュレーション

ideologue — 思想家、特定の主義を強く主張する人

algorithm — アルゴリズム

Question 1 — Questions

Q1 1

What is the main idea expressed in the underlined sentence (A)?

- ① The author wants to dismiss our love of stories as childish.
- ② The author is asking why stories have such a powerful effect on us.
- ③ The author argues that fictional stories should be avoided.
- ④ The author claims that only true stories matter.

Q2 2

According to the passage, why are stories important for human survival?

- ① They provide entertainment after a hard day of work.
- ② They help us remember critical information in a memorable form.
- ③ They allow ancient people to compete with other tribes.
- ④ They are required by religious traditions.

Q3 3

What does the underlined sentence (B) mean?

- ① Our brains have changed completely from those of our ancestors.
- ② Stories no longer affect modern people the way they once did.
- ③ Stories still produce strong, measurable effects in the modern brain.
- ④ Modern technology has replaced the need for stories.

Q4

4

Which of the following best paraphrases the underlined sentence (C)?

- ① Good stories are simply enjoyable, but nothing more.
- ② A good story enlarges the range of experiences we can have.
- ③ Stories make us forget the boundaries of reality entirely.
- ④ Stories are only valuable if they describe real events.

Q5

5

What danger does the passage identify in our love of stories (underlined part D)?

- ① Stories may cause us to become bored with real life.
- ② Stories can be used by others to manipulate our behavior.
- ③ Stories prevent us from learning factual information.
- ④ Stories take up time we should spend on exercise.

Q6

6

Which statement best summarizes the underlined sentence (E)?

- ① Stories are an outdated form of human communication.
- ② Stories will disappear as artificial intelligence grows more powerful.
- ③ Stories remain the essential way humans make sense of themselves and each other.
- ④ Stories are useful only for entertainment, not understanding.